

The Nabis

In 1888, a number of painters in Paris formed a secretive group they called the Nabis (Hebrew for prophets). Led by Paul Sérusier, they included Pierre Bonnard (1867–1947), Édouard Vuillard (1868–1940) and Maurice Denis (1870–1943). Denis summed up their beliefs: 'A picture, before being a warhorse, a nude, or some kind of story, is essentially a flat surface covered with colours arranged in a certain order.'

During a painting lesson with Gauguin in 1888 in the Bois d'Amour on the bank of Brittany's Aven River, Sérusier learned to intensify colour and simplify form. He took the resulting painting – a small, near-abstract landscape of patches of simplified, non-naturalistic colour – back to the Académie Julian in Paris where the work astonished his fellow students Bonnard, Denis and Vuillard. They nicknamed it *The Talisman*, after a secret, magical object, and it inspired them to form the Nabis, following Gauguin, and making their images of nature personal and symbolic. They exerted a major influence on other art produced in France at the time.



Sérusier, *The Talisman*, 1888